

CHAMAELEON

THE CHAMELEON

A SMALL AND INSIGNIFICANT CONSTELLATION NEAR THE SOUTH CELESTIAL POLE, CHAMELEON WAS ONE OF THE CONSTELLATIONS INTRODUCED IN THE 1590S BY PETRUS PLANCIUS.

Chamaeleon's faint diamond pattern of stars lies between the star fields of Carina and the South Celestial Pole in Octans. None of its stars is bright and there are no associated legends. Eta Chamaeleontis is the brightest star in an open star cluster, and Delta Chamaeleontis is a pair of unrelated stars. The Chamaeleon I Cloud is a star-forming nebula some 500 light-years away.

► The Chamaeleon I Cloud

A star is pictured in the process of forming within the Chamaeleon I Cloud. Gas jetting out from its poles collides with surrounding gas and lights up the region.



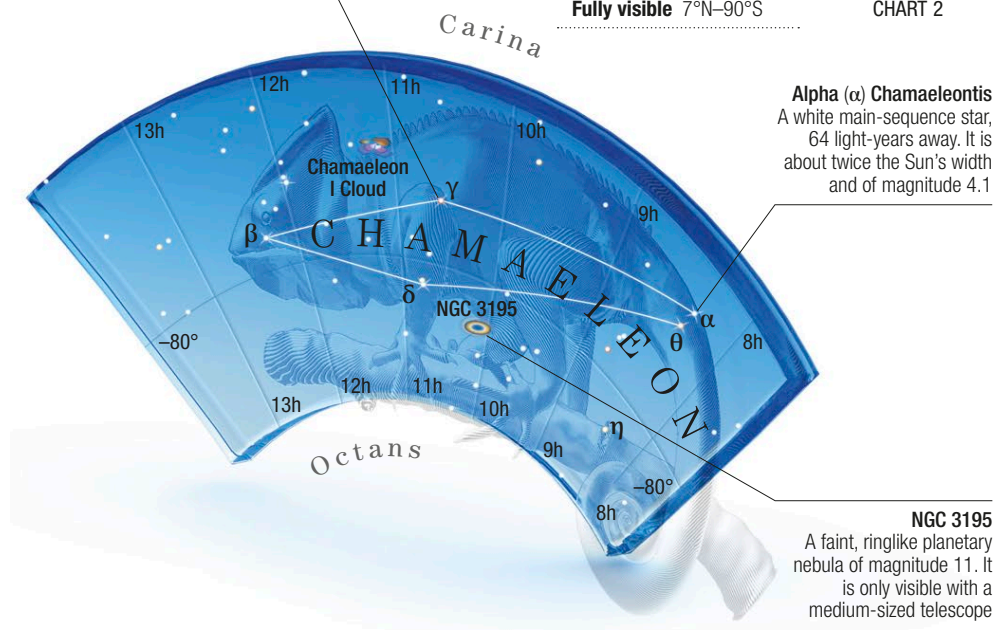
Gamma (γ) Chamaeleontis
This red giant of magnitude 4.1 and 417 light-years away is also an irregular variable star

KEY DATA

Size ranking 79
Brightest stars Alpha (α) 4.1, Gamma (γ) 4.1
Genitive Chamaeleontis
Abbreviation Cha
Highest in sky at 10pm February–May
Fully visible 7°N–90°S



CHART 2



APUS

THE BIRD OF PARADISE

ONE OF THE 12 FAR SOUTHERN CONSTELLATIONS INTRODUCED AT THE END OF THE 16TH CENTURY, THIS TROPICAL BIRD IS DRAWN AROUND A CHAIN OF FOUR INDISTINCT STARS.

Apus lies south of an obvious triangle of stars, Triangulum Australe, and occupies an almost featureless area near the South Celestial Pole. It was devised by Dutch navigators Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman after seeing the exotic bird-of-paradise during their explorations of New Guinea in the 1590s. Sharp eyes or binoculars show that the constellation's most interesting star, Delta Apodis, is a double—a wide pair of unrelated red giants of magnitudes 4.7 and 5.3, 310 light-years away. Other notable features are Theta Apodis, a red giant varying between magnitudes 6.4 and 8.0 about every four months, and the globular clusters IC 4499 and NGC 6101.

KEY DATA

Size ranking 67
Brightest stars Alpha (α) 3.8, Gamma (γ) 3.9
Genitive Apodis
Abbreviation Aps
Highest in sky at 10pm May–July
Fully visible 7°N–90°S



CHART 2

